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My Third Visit to the US and Canada

MY THIRD and last Punjab-related visit to Canada and the US took place in September–October 1983, when Prime Minister Indira Gandhi was to address a session of the United Nations General Assembly at New York. As was the case during my previous two visits, I actually held the charge of deputy director overseeing two of the most sensitive divisions at the R&AW headquarters (the second one after it fell vacant in the middle of 1982). The work handled by these divisions had nothing to do with the coverage of Sikh extremist or Khalistan-related activities abroad. However, I was called upon as a sort of firefighter, to perform a special task in the US and Canada, report compliance of the orders to the director (R), and get back to my officially assigned duties.

At this time, Punjab was on the boil. DIG A.S. Atwal had been murdered a few months before, on 25 April 1983. Amrik Singh had criticized Hindus openly in the presence of Bhindranwale and Longowal at an AISSF conclave (described in the preceding chapter). Within days of Indira Gandhi's return from New York, six Hindus were dragged out of a bus on the night of 5 October and shot dead. That incident led to the dismissal of Darbara Singh's Congress government and imposition of president's rule in Punjab. Naturally, the developments in Punjab also had a serious impact on the Indian diaspora in the US and Canada.